

LIFE-STUDY OF EPHESIANS
MESSAGE FORTY-THREE
ARRIVING AT THREE THINGS
(con't)

III. ARRIVING AT THE MEASURE OF THE STATURE OF THE FULLNESS OF CHRIST

According to verse 13, we also are to arrive at the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ. The fullness of Christ is the Body of Christ (1:23), which has a stature with a measure. To arrive at the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ is also a necessity for the practical oneness. Hence, to go from the oneness of reality to the oneness of practicality we need to press onward until we arrive at the three things mentioned in this verse.

The fullness of Christ is simply the expression of Christ. As Christ's fullness, the Body is Christ's expression. Christ's fullness, the Body, has a stature, and with this stature there is a certain measure. Hence, verse 13 speaks of the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ.

To arrive at the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ is to arrive at the full building up of the Body of Christ. It is to arrive at the full completion of the building up of the Body.

We have seen that we need to arrive at the practical oneness, at the full growth, and at the complete building up of the Body. If we would arrive at these three things, we need to do the work of ministry. As verse 12 indicates, the work of ministry is equal to building up the Body of Christ. Among us there is just one ministry. Although thousands of us may participate in the work of ministry, the ministry itself is unique. This ministry is strictly for the building up of the Body of Christ. No matter who we may be, leaders or followers, we all are working to carry out the ministry in the New Testament economy to build up the Body of Christ. We are not here to go on alone, but to go on with others, even to bring others on. As we ourselves go on, we need to bring others on. We take others on by speaking for Christ, by teaching, and by shepherding.

Once again I wish to point out the need in all the churches for some kind of practical training. We need to be trained in the matters of teaching, shepherding, and preaching the gospel. Through this training the saints will learn how to function as apostles, prophets, evangelists, and shepherds and teachers. As we function in all these ways, we have one goal: the building up of the Body of Christ. As we participate in the work of ministry for the building up of the Body, we arrive at the practical oneness, at full growth, and at the completion of the building up of the Body of Christ.

If our only goal is the building up of the Body, we shall spontaneously be regulated. As we carry on a particular work, it will be with the consciousness that this work is for the building up of the Body. Formerly, we may have preached the gospel without realizing that gospel preaching must be for the building up of the Body. Now we see that whatever we may do as apostles, prophets, evangelists, and shepherds and teachers must be for the unique goal of building up Christ's Body. If we have seen the goal, then we shall be burdened to help others arrive with us at the practical oneness, at the full growth, and at the full building up of the Body. If we are clear about this, then the Lord will have a way to come back, for He will have a way to obtain the Bride He desires.

The Lord's way to do this is found in three crucial verses—in Ephesians 4:11-13. These verses reveal that all those who have been captured by the Lord have been presented to the Body as gifts for the perfecting of the saints, so that the work of ministry may be carried out and that the building up of the Body of Christ may

be accomplished. Then we shall all arrive together at our destination—at the oneness of the faith and of the full knowledge of the Son of God, at a full-grown man, and at the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ. This is our goal, and we must diligently press toward it until we all reach it together.

LIFE-STUDY OF EPHESIANS
MESSAGE FORTY-FOUR
BABYISHNESS AND THE WINDS OF TEACHING

Ephesians 4:13 says that we need to arrive at the oneness of the faith and of the full knowledge of the Son of God, at a full-grown man, and at the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ. It is difficult to define these items adequately because they are all related to life and life is very mysterious. The real oneness in practicality is a matter of life. Likewise, the full-grown man and the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ are matters of life. Only after our experience of life has reached a certain degree can we understand such a verse as 4:13.

In 4:13 Paul begins with the oneness of the faith. From my limited experience, I can say that the faith here refers to Christ with His redemptive work. Hence, the object of our Christian faith is the living Christ with His work.

Verse 13 also speaks of the full knowledge of the Son of God. Apparently, there is little relationship between the faith and the full knowledge of the Son of God. According to our experience, however, the two are actually one, for both refer to Christ. The full knowledge of the Son of God is a matter of knowing Christ as life and everything to us. In the New Testament the Lord is called the Son of God in relation to life, but in relation to His commission He is called Christ. When Peter received the revelation regarding Christ, he said that the Lord Jesus was the Christ, the Son of the living God (Matt. 16:16). Furthermore, in the Gospel of John we are told that we need to believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God (John 20:31). This means that we believe in the Lord Jesus for life and for His commission. To know the Lord's commission is rather easy, but to know Him as our life is quite difficult. This comes not by mere objective knowledge, but by experience. When we experience Christ as our life, we know Him as the Son of God. Then we have the experiential and practical oneness, that is, the oneness of the faith and of the full knowledge of the Son of God.

God desires that Christ be everything to us. Christ is the object of our faith, and He is also our life. If we see this, we shall begin to lay aside whatever distracts us from Christ; we shall drop everything other than Christ Himself. How much we drop depends on our experience of Christ. The more we experience Christ as life, the more things we shall lay aside. In this way we arrive at the oneness of the faith and of the full knowledge of the Son of God.

Today, because we are still short of the experience of life, we do not have the full realization of this practical oneness. But we are growing. We cannot say that we have arrived at the oneness of the faith and of the full knowledge of the Son of God, at a full-grown man, or at the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ. Nevertheless, we thank the Lord that, in His recovery, we are on the way toward this goal.

I. BABES IN CHRIST

Verse 14 says, "That we may be no longer babes tossed by waves and carried about by every wind of teaching in the sleight of men, in craftiness with a view to a system of error." This verse is the continuation of verse 13. The word "that," which may also be rendered "in order that," indicates that the result of arriving at the three things in verse 13 is that we are no longer babes tossed by waves and carried about by every

wind of teaching. Therefore, arriving at the three things in verse 13 has a purpose, and this purpose is that we be no longer babes.

A. Those Lacking Maturity in Life

Babes are those believers who are young in Christ, who lack maturity in life (1 Cor. 3:1; 13:11; Heb. 5:13). In the first stage of our spiritual life, we Christians are all babes.

B. Tossed by Waves and Carried About by Winds

Verse 14 indicates that the babes are tossed by waves. The Christian life is like a journey on the sea, where there are many storms. As Christians, we should not expect our journey to be calm, with no waves or winds. The waves and the storms come not only upon individual believers, but even upon the church. There are times when the church experiences waves and is in the midst of storms. Paul's concept here is not that we can avoid the waves and winds, but that we can be kept from being tossed by waves and carried about by winds.

Difficulties and hardships are different from waves and storms. Hardships are like rocks, and difficulties are like heavy weights that we must bear. Waves, on the contrary, often come in a pleasant, appealing way and even with a sweet, loving appearance. Most of those who are tossed by waves are not tossed against their will, but are tossed willingly by waves that seem most pleasant and enjoyable to them. As they are being tossed by the waves, they have no sense of danger. Rather, they may have a sense of excitement or enjoyment. Because waves may have such a pleasant appearance, they are quite different from hardships or difficulties. Actually, few Christians are tossed by difficulties, but many are tossed by waves and carried away by winds.

Perhaps you are wondering what the waves and the winds are. They are the various teachings, doctrines, concepts, and opinions. As the church is journeying on the sea, Satan will seek an opportunity to send in some appealing teachings, concepts, and opinions to entice the believers. His purpose in doing so is to carry them away from Christ and the church.